

# THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp

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WEDNESDAY, APRIL 8, 2026 ~ VOL. CCLXXXVII NO. 81

WSJ.com

★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 46584.46 ▼ 85.42 0.18% NASDAQ 22017.85 ▲ 0.1% STOXX 600 590.59 ▼ 1.0% 10-YR. TREAS. ▼ 2/32, yield 4.342% OIL \$112.95 ▲ \$0.54 GOLD \$4,657.10 ▲ \$0.30 EURO \$1.1599 YEN 159.62

## What's News

### Business & Finance

- ◆ **Trader fatigue helped** to shape a muted close for major U.S. stock indexes, with the S&P 500 rising less than 0.1%, the Nasdaq gaining 0.1% and the Dow industrials falling 0.2%. **B1**
- ◆ **Pershing Square said** it offered to buy Universal Music Group in a deal that values the world's largest record label at about \$60 billion. **A1**
- ◆ **The Treasury Department** proposed regulations that it said would fundamentally reset the U.S.'s anti-money-laundering rules, handing banks another victory. **A2**
- ◆ **The U.K. barred entry** to Kanye West following a backlash over a planned performance at a London music festival and the rapper's history of antisemitism. **B3**
- ◆ **Elon Musk is working** with Intel on his Terafab project, which aims to build specially designed chips for SpaceX, xAI and Tesla. **B4**
- ◆ **Anthropic is preparing** to arm some of the biggest technology companies with tools to find and patch bugs in their hardware and software. **B4**
- ◆ **Novo Nordisk launched** its higher-dose Wegovy weight-loss shot in the U.S. after regulators cleared it for distribution there. **B3**
- ◆ **Gilead agreed to buy** German biotech company Tubulis for \$3.15 billion to expand its portfolio of a cancer technology that aims to better guide chemotherapies to tumors. **B3**
- ◆ **Delta Air Lines will** increase fees for checked bags on domestic and select short-haul international routes as carriers look to offset soaring jet-fuel costs. **B3**

### Worldwide

- ◆ **Trump backed down** from a threat to wipe out the entirety of Iranian civilization, saying he had agreed to a two-week cease-fire deal with Iran in the hope that Washington and Tehran would be able to complete a long-term peace agreement. **A1, A6-7**
- ◆ **Oil futures shed more** than \$10 a barrel to drop below \$100 a barrel Tuesday evening in New York after Trump's announcement on social media. **A6**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** has rebuffed requests from Ford and other U.S. automakers for relief from aluminum tariffs after fires at a major American factory created supply bottlenecks. **A3**
- ◆ **The U.S. made a public** show of backing Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán in his bid for re-election with an appearance by Vice President JD Vance at a political event in Budapest. **A8**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** is hanging on to the \$70 million jet that Kristi Noem leased during her tenure atop the Department of Homeland Security. **A3**
- ◆ **Republican Clayton Fuller** won the special election for Georgia's 14th Congressional District, formerly held by Marjorie Taylor Greene. **A4**
- ◆ **Federal authorities** said Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers shot and injured an immigrant during a targeted traffic stop in Northern California. **A4**
- ◆ **Three assailants** opened fire at police outside a building housing the Israeli Consulate in Istanbul, starting a gunfight that left one attacker dead. **A8**

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## Trump Backs Off Threat to Level Iran

President says at 11th hour he agreed to a two-week cease-fire after warning ‘a whole civilization will die tonight’



AP/GETTY IMAGES

Iranians rallied in Tehran after a cease-fire was announced shortly before President Trump's deadline to wipe out the country.

President Trump backed down Tuesday from a threat to wipe out the entirety of Iranian civilization, saying he agreed to a two-week cease-fire deal with Iran in hopes the countries will be able to finalize a long-term peace agreement.

By Alexander Ward, Summer Said and Alyssa Lukpat

“We have already met and exceeded all Military objectives,” Trump wrote on Truth Social, “and are very far along with a definitive Agreement concerning Longterm PEACE with Iran, and PEACE in the Middle East.”

Trump said that the agreement was “subject to the Islamic Republic of Iran agreeing to the COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and SAFE OPENING of the Strait of Hormuz.”

Iran said it had achieved its war aims and signaled its intent to continue control over the strait, the world's most important energy-shipping lane.

Trump posted his statement about 90 minutes before a deadline he set for Tehran to cede to his demands and more than 10 hours after he threatened to annihilate the country. The president's threat to wipe out Iran sparked a backlash in Washington, with lawmakers on both sides of the aisle criticizing the president's rhetoric.

“A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again. I don't want that to happen, but it probably will,” Trump wrote on Truth Social on Tuesday morning. The president added that “maybe something revolutionary will happen” because of the many killings of Iranian leaders, which he considers regime change.

The U.S. halted all offensive operations in Iran following the president's Tuesday evening announcement, according to a senior U.S. official.

“The reason for doing so is that we have already met and exceeded all Military objectives.”

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- ◆ **Lawmakers weigh reining in Trump**..... A6
- ◆ **U.S. oil retreats to below \$100 level**..... A6
- ◆ **Traders raced before Iran deadline**..... B1

## The Day Trump's Threat Gripped World

By WSJ Staff

At 8:06 a.m. EDT Tuesday, President Trump issued the most dramatic ultimatum of his presidency: Unless Iran struck a deal in the next 12 hours, “a whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again.”

Even for a president who has long relied on maximalist threats, the 85-word post was startling. It ricocheted from the Oval Office to foreign embassies and corporate suites, setting off a countdown to Trump's 8 p.m. deadline and a frantic global guessing game over what the world's most powerful man was

prepared to do.

Less than 90 minutes before his deadline, Trump backed down, writing in a social-media post that he had agreed to a two-week cease-fire with Iran and would suspend his threatened strikes subject to the immediate reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump had spent days warning that he would bomb Iran's bridges, power plants and other civilian infrastructure, insisting the country's people “would be willing to suffer that in order to have freedom.” As he appeared to threaten to destroy a country of 93 million people, he also

seemed to leave the door open to a deal to avert the calamitous strikes.

“WHO KNOWS?” he wrote on Tuesday morning. “We will find out tonight, one of the most important moments in the long and complex history of the World.”

As the hours ticked by, everyone from Pope Leo to actor Ben Stiller called on Trump to back down. Administration officials fielded phone calls from executives and political allies trying to decipher whether Trump's threat was a bluff or a prelude to an escalation.

European officials huddled on a call and largely convinced

themselves that Trump would back off. On Wall Street, traders and executives treated the day like other Trump deadlines that have come and gone: as a negotiating tactic they largely expected to pass without catastrophe.

Trump's social-media post lighted up group chats across the globe and set off a scramble by U.S. allies and mediators to find an off-ramp or buy more time.

As his threat made the rounds in Iran, many residents prepared for power and gas to go out and debated whether it would be safer to stay in the

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## Activist Launches \$60 Billion Universal Music Bid

By GARETH VIPERS

Bill Ackman's Pershing Square Capital said it had made an offer to buy Universal Music Group in a deal that values the company at about \$60 billion, the latest attempt by the activist investor to land the world's largest record label.

The deal for the company that works with Bad Bunny, Taylor Swift and the Beatles, if approved, would close by the end of the year and would involve Universal merging with Pershing Square Sparc Holdings, a specially created acquisition vehicle. The new entity would be based in Nevada and would shift its stock listing from Amsterdam to the New York Stock Exchange, Pershing said.

“UMG's stock price has languished due to a combination of issues that are unrelated to the performance of its music business and importantly, all of them can be addressed with this transaction,” Pershing's Chief Executive Bill Ackman said on Tuesday.

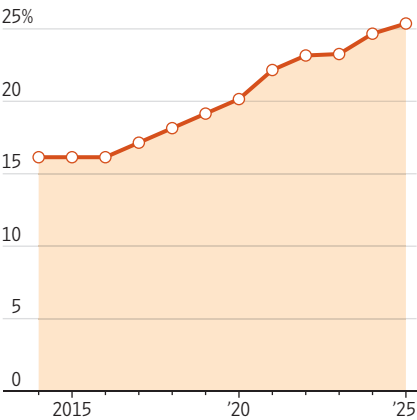
Universal counts some of the world's biggest-selling artists on its books, including Bob Dylan, Kendrick Lamar, Elton John, Coldplay and Billie Eilish. One of the “big three” record labels alongside

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## Private Credit Haunts Insurers

As private credit boomed, the industry found the nation's insurance companies to be a ready source of capital. Of the about \$6 trillion in invested assets held by life and annuity companies, nearly \$1 trillion is now in private-credit investments. **B1**

Private credit as a share of life and annuity insurers' fixed-income investments



Note: Includes direct loans, bank loans, asset-backed finance and 'rated feeders.' Source: A.M. Best

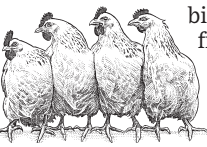
## This Is One Job Accountants Would Love for AI to Take Over

Auditors are still sent on messy trips to count chickens, rocks, corn and frozen fish

By MARK MAURER

Matt Gardiner recently climbed a series of 90-foot grain bins to measure millions of bushels of corn.

He and his team got so covered in thick dust that they had to be sprayed down with air hoses before returning to their cars. It's one of the hazards of the job, along with fertilizer-soaked boots, ripped pants from ladder cages, and encounters with pigeons, mice and sleeping bats. Gardiner isn't a farmer.



One, two, three, four...

He's an accountant.

The third-generation Iowa-based auditor has to review and verify the financials compiled by his clients, largely agricultural businesses. He uses a laser to measure grain, but there's no tool inside the bins that can save him from having to climb. “There's so much dust in the process of getting grain into a bin that it would have to have a little windshield wiper on the sensors to constantly clear it,” Gardiner said. “I think that'd be great.”

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## Office Buildings Sell At Fire-Sale Discount

By PETER GRANT

The U.S.'s battered office market is holding a fire sale, featuring some buildings marked down by more than 90%.

In Chicago, real-estate developer Marc Calabria bought a 485,000-square-foot office building for \$4 million. The building sold for \$68.1 million a decade ago.

Developer Asher Luzzatto paid a mere \$5.3 million for the Denver Energy Center after

a foreclosure process. The two-building complex sold for \$176 million in 2013.

Even the federal government's landlord is getting in on the act. The General Services Administration sold last month a 940,000-square-foot building to a residential converter for \$24 million, a tiny fraction of its value a few years ago.

Landlords and their lenders held on to their office towers

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## The Go-To Guy In a Remade DOJ

Federal prosecutor Robert Keenan was floundering until the new administration

By JOE PALAZZOLO

In a federal courthouse in Los Angeles last spring, Judge Otis Wright II, a no-nonsense former Marine, was baffled by what he was hearing from the prosecutor before him.

The judge had recently received notice from the Justice Department that the new administration was reviewing the conviction of Alexander Smirnov, an FBI informant who admitted to fabricating claims that former President Joe Biden and his son, Hunter, accepted bribes from a Ukrainian company.

“There's a great book by Dennis Prager called ‘Think a Second Time,’” said Robert Keenan, the prosecutor, referring to the conservative talk show host. “There's no harm in looking at something anew and making sure we got it right.”

And not only that: The department was joining Smirnov's defense lawyers in seeking his release while he appealed the six-year prison sentence that Wright had issued earlier that year.

“Seriously?” said Judge Wright, a nearly 20-year veteran.

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